and elsewhere were also often forced (or simply chose) to leave. Certainly the majority of these local ethnic Germans (although not all of them) had often been sympathetic to Hitler and the Nazis, and some were involved in war crimes too. Under special decrees by the then Czech President Beneš, almost all Czech Germans were forced to leave the country, leading to a bitterness that is still around today. It was at least partially alleviated by a solemn declaration made by Václav Havel and Helmut Kohl in 1992, addressing both the 1938 Munich Agreement which led to the annexation by Hitler of the areas of the Czech lands populated by ethnic Germans, and the forced expulsion of ethnic Germans from the same areas after World War II.[35] It took another quarter of a century for a joint committee of Czech and Austrian historians to produce a common account of the history of these two nations. But the mere fact that the two countries (perhaps even more so Austria) felt the need to commission such a report testifies to the depth of the Germanic-Slavic conflict and also of the importance of history in Central Europe.[36]

In Slovenia, there was not exactly a forced expulsion but the measures adopted against the 'sympathisers of the occupying forces' had a similar effect on a much smaller scale. Here, the situation was even more complicated. While most ethnic Germans were living in the urban centres of Yugoslavia before World War II, there was also the very special case of an ethnic-German community in south-east Slovenia, around the town of Kočevje. These so-called Kočevje (or Gottscheer) Germans were the remains of medieval German colonisation, a closely-knit community that preserved an archaic form of German. They had worked hard through centuries, clearing the woods to create a flourishing farming society which lived in a fairly harmonious relationship with the surrounding ethnic Slovenians until the advent of Nazism – Hitler's emissaries began to fuel unrest and pro-Nazi sentiment among them, promising their return to the original homeland. But, when World War II broke out, the Kočevje area fell into the Italian zone of occupation. So Hitler, in keeping with the promise, and Mussolini, eager to round up the territory, agreed to have them removed from their traditional homes and sent not to their medieval lands of origin in heartland Germany, but to places of the forcibly enlarged Third Reich from which local Slovenians had, only days before, been expelled and despatched to Germany, Serbia and elsewhere.